

2025 is arguably one of the most significant turning points in American politics and culture. Media has been filled up with families being torn apart, neighbors being detained, and friends being deported. Americans are divided on the matter—some argue that the “mass deportations” violate human rights, while others claim the actions are necessary for national safety.

The question should not be whether immigration is good or bad; it should be, “How can immigration uphold American values?” The Constitution states, “We the People of the United States, in Order to form a more perfect Union, establish Justice, insure domestic Tranquility, provide for the common defense, promote the general Welfare, and secure the Blessings of Liberty to ourselves and our Posterity, do ordain and establish this Constitution for the United States of America.” Like the rest of American legislation, immigration policies should promote American wealth, safety, and sovereignty.

Since the 1980s, illegal immigration has grown as an issue. Respectively in 2012 and 2014, President Obama introduced Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) and Deferred Action for Parents of Americans (DAPA) to prevent the separation of undocumented immigrants and their American-born children [1]. Conversely, in 2016, President Trump tightened immigration measures. In addition to building a border wall, Title 42 expelled 400,000 unauthorized migrants, and the “zero tolerance policy” separated 3,900 children from their undocumented parents [2]. By 2019, the number of illegal immigrants in America had dropped to a decade-low of 10.2 million people [3]. In 2021, President Biden halted the border wall’s construction and encouraged family reunification for undocumented immigrants. As an alternative to immigration detention, Biden’s “catch and release” policy released migrants awaiting immigration status into public communities. This caused a first-time rise in illegal immigration, reaching 11 million illegal immigrants in the U.S. by 2022 [4]. In 2025, the Trump

administration pulled the “catch and release” policy, declared a national emergency at the border, and now plans to complete the border wall [5]. All these swinging policies cause one to ask, “How have recent immigration policies contributed to American values?”

As stated in the Constitution, enriching American wealth is one goal of immigration. In 2009, illegal households used \$28.8 billion in government resources, while contributing \$9.5 billion in taxes [6]. Furthermore, illegal immigration often results in lower wages for legal workers. In 2019, undocumented workers earned 42% less than citizens and legal immigrants [7]. When employers hire illegal workers, it lowers wages and working conditions for legal residents. When illegal workers do not pay taxes, a lowered federal tax income burdens American taxpayers.

New immigrants should fill both high and low skill labor gaps without harming the American public. In the early 1900s, immigrants entering Ellis Island were required to have at least \$25.00 to ensure that they would not immediately go on welfare. Similarly, the U.S. should prioritize high-skilled workers who are not only self-sufficient, but also offer knowledge, skills, and innovation. Yet, America still needs low-skilled labor— although this may decrease with the development of AI and the robot industry. To prevent deteriorating conditions and wages, the U.S. could implement a minimum wage. This will balance competition between native and foreign workers while protecting the rights of parties.

Public safety is another priority of American immigration. The Constitution mandates that legislation “insure domestic Tranquility” and “provide for the common defence.” Criminal convictions and immigration violations doubled from fiscal years 2021 to 2023 [8]. In 1998, 63% of all federal arrests were of U.S. citizens; in 2018, 64% of all federal arrests were of non-U.S. citizens [9]. These significant shifts undermine American safety and security.

While migrants will always seek illegal ways to enter our nation, securing the border is the first step. Texas's Operation Lone Star highlights the effectiveness of stronger border security. Since 2021, the program has resulted in an 86% decrease in illegal crossings [10]. Combined with deploying AI technologies such as drones and robots, the border wall can be transformed into a "smart" wall, ensuring the safety of the American people on a higher level.

Above all, immigration must be conducted under American sovereignty. Welcoming illegal immigrants is simply unfair to those immigrating the legal way. Since 2021, Customs and Border Protection has recorded over 10.8 million encounters with illegal immigrants [11]. Recent policies not only were weak on these threats, but supported them by offering benefits to lawbreakers. In 2022, 4.4 million U.S.-born children lived with illegal immigrant parents [12]. This is a clear example of how loopholes in U.S. immigration law have been exploited. Compassion must be shown towards the millions of families who have suffered because of an unclear and inaccessible immigration system that encouraged them to risk illegal immigration. Yet, this is precisely the reason why immigration policies need to change; more suffering must be prevented in the future. The rule of law of the people cannot bend to an individual's emotions. Thus, America should establish clear consequences of breaking the law.

Ultimately, the U.S. can encourage legal over illegal entry by increasing more lawful opportunities. For example, a point-based immigration system would acknowledge family relations, employment, and humanitarian aid as important factors to one's entry. A transparent and accessible point-based approach will encourage more immigrants with valuable contributions to come to America. This system has already been adopted by Canada, the United Kingdom, and Australia. Fulfilling the Constitutional values, a point-based system would "establish Justice" in the American immigration system and relieve hardships for those coming to our nation in the future.

Immigration has been a debated issue from the birth of our nation through the Civil War, the World Wars, and the post-war era. As this discussion will inevitably go on, we must be grounded by the values of America as stated in the Constitution. Let us welcome new immigrants to keep America “a city upon a hill”, promoting wealth, security, and sovereignty for both itself and the world.

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